

Mesopotamian civilizations

More than 5,000 years ago, the world's first known cities appeared in Mesopotamia, a historical region now found largely within the borders of modern-day Iraq. Mesopotamia was also the birthplace of many features of civilization, including rulership by a king or queen, armies, organized religion, and legal systems.

Mesopotamia, which means “the land between the rivers,” lay between the Tigris and Euphrates rivers. These waterways flooded every year, which could ruin farmers’ crops. The Mesopotamians worked together to control the flood water, building dykes to protect their fields, and canals and reservoirs to store the water for later use. These activities gave rise to a high level of social

organization and cooperation. It also created huge harvests, and enough food for growing populations.

It was in southern Mesopotamia, in a land originally called Sumer, that villages grew into the world's first cities. Uruk and Ur had populations of tens of thousands of people. They were ruled over by monarchs who claimed to reign on behalf of the local god.

▼ WARFARE

The world's earliest recorded wars took place in Mesopotamia. Cities fought each other over land, and foreign invaders attacked the region for its great wealth. This mosaic on a box from Ur shows a king and his army celebrating a victory over their enemies.



KEY

- Mesopotamia
- Sumer

◀ THE TWO RIVERS

The Tigris and Euphrates flow from the mountains of what is now Turkey, through present-day Iraq, and into the Persian Gulf. The Mesopotamian civilization began in Sumer in the southeast and later spread across the whole region.

RISE OF CIVILIZATIONS

c. 4000 BCE

The villages in Uruk come together to form the world's first known city. It has walls around its boundaries and contains great monuments. People are divided into classes based on what they do. There were classes for priests, merchants, and craftworkers, among others.

c. 3300–3100 BCE

Around a dozen city-states emerge in Sumer, each ruled by a monarch. The Sumerians develop cuneiform, a writing system consisting of marks pressed onto clay tablets.



CUNEIFORM TABLET

c. 3000 BCE

The Sumerians learn to make bronze, by mixing tin and copper imported from neighboring lands. The bronze is used to make tools, weapons, and sculptures. The people of Sumer also make four-wheeled chariots for use in warfare.